STALIN SECURES THE SOUTHERN CITADEL

The INDIA bloc led by the DMK in the state refuses to let the BJP in through the door, or cede even an inch to the AIADMK. With two years to go for the assembly election, more Centre-state friction looms on the horizon along with potential political realignments

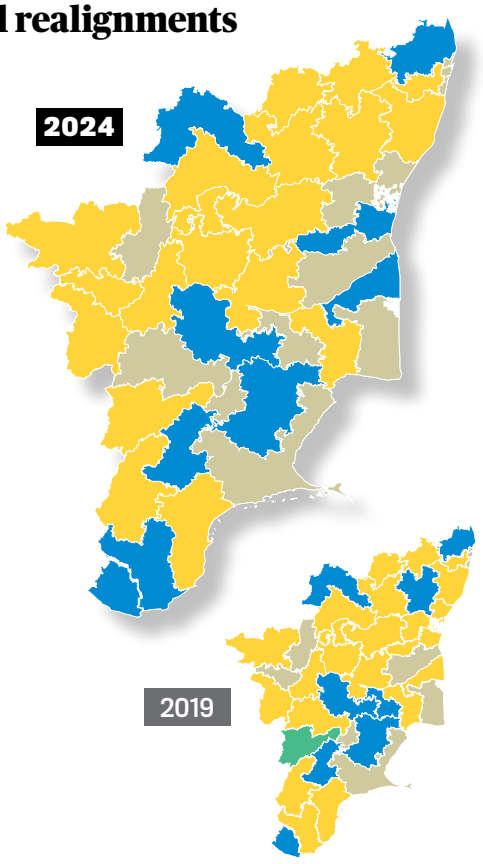
By **Amarnath K. Menon**

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's rallying cry of *'Naarpathum Namathe'* (All Forty are Ours) resounded loudly, enabling his Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam-led Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA) to sweep all 39 Lok Sabha constituencies in Tamil Nadu, along with the lone Puducherry seat. For the All India Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), hoping to reverse its fortunes after the 2019 setback—when it had won just one seat, down from 37 in 2014—this complete rout proved to be yet another disappointment.

In the wake of the Bharatiya Janata Party's push into the southern citadel, the contest was also seen as a clash between Hindutva and the Dravidian ideology. Denying the saffron party a toehold, the DMK chief came up trumps in that battle too. "It's a massive, historic victory for our DMK-led alliance," Stalin declared after the win. "The BJP's plan to rewrite the Constitution and its hate campaign failed to cut ice with people."

Having stitched together a winning coalition with the Congress, the Left and other like-minded parties even while in the Opposition, the DMK persisted with it. Stalin's welfare initiatives, particularly those empowering women voters—otherwise a core AIADMK voter base since its founder M.G. Ramachandran's era—proved catalytic. Free bus travel for women, monthly Rs 1,000 allowance for women heads of households and free school meals resonated deeply with the working class. But some analysts do attribute the SPA's spectacular win to "Modi phobia" rather than any pro-incumbency for the DMK regime.

As the DMK surged ahead, the AIADMK- and BJP-led fronts vied for runner-up position. While the AIADMK emerged second in 24 seats, with allies coming second in three more, the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) finished second in just 12 constituencies. The BJP state chief K. Annamalai's high-decibel campaign



TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 39

	DMK	CONG.	AIADMK	BJP
2024	22 (26.9%)	9 (10.7%)	0 (20.4%)	0 (11.2%)
2019	24 (33.5%)	8 (12.6%)	1 (19.4%)	0 (3.7%)

DMK-Congress allies Vote share in ( )